

Dell Has Everything to Beat Apple

Does the PC manufacturer have the will to take the controls back from Apple, or will it continue losing market share to the Mac?

Windows is passé! Nobody seems to talk about it any more, except for, well, Microsoft! And even the folks from Redmond may shy away if you say something that sounds like 'Vista'. Now, the rage seems to be the Mac, and GNU/Linux, of course.

Apple's Mac has increased its share in the market post the Vista release. The market was ready for a new OS, but Vista disappointed users. GNU/Linux is putting up a good fight, but it has some distance to cover with respect to a few niche desktop use-cases.

Apple's heat

The heat created by Apple is burning the fingers of players like Dell, HP and many others. Owing to the soggy operating system that runs on their machines, they are losing market share to Apple. They have no other option but Vista, which simply turns users off and thus forces them to switch to the alternative called Mac. Dell did try to fight back by ceding to customer demands to continue shipping with XP, but you can't win a race in a vintage car when Apple is rolling out Ferraris, right?

The end user is in an even sorrier situation: the lack of an alternative option by PC vendors forces them towards Macs, and the moment they buy one, they submit themselves to be locked in Apple's airtight compartment, where every bit of freedom is denied and every breath you take is controlled by the company. On top of it, Macs are expensive too. Well, so is Vista. The reason people go for Macs is the 'cool' factor. The graphics, the style, the looks, and the interface—everything is up to the mark, almost perfect.

So, those who want an awesome experience, choose Macs and those who can't afford it, or are simply willing to compromise, go for Windows. Of course, the smarter lot goes for GNU/Linux.

No doubt, GNU/Linux is a killer in the server space and in many other domains like embedded systems. An

ordinary home user can do a whole lot on GNU/Linux, but not everything. Professionals can't use high-end software for tasks like film, audio and image editing. Yes, there is the GIMP, but no Photoshop.

This is less of a problem for Microsoft, but a pain for vendors who have a very strong focus on desktop users—think of Dell! The company recently launched a much-hyped series of computers, branded Adamo. It looks good... it is slim. Well OK... but what does it run on? Umm ... Windows Vista. "No, I don't want to spend that much money to buy another Vista. I will go for a Mac this time!"

Well, you can see Dell sweating! But, Dell is one company that can rewrite history and become the company with the highest selling machines in the world. The company now has the muscle and the curves—look at Adamo and you will know what I mean. It just misses one core thing, and that could turn people off.

Dell can do an Apple

Dell can have its own OS running on its machines. An OS that will be much more secure, and that will beat Mac in design and usage. What's more, Dell doesn't have to do much—all it takes is the desire to rule the market.

The OS is already there, you know what I am talking about—GNU/Linux. Dell can use Ubuntu, one of the most popular GNU/Linux distros, or even Debian... or anything else, for that matter. All it needs to do is customise the flavour of GNU/Linux to a level where it gets the glossy looks and glitz of the Mac—heck, it is possible to outshine a Mac.

Top priority

Dell can work with teams of developers to give a cool look and feel to the GNU/Linux operating systems. Check out the ease of GNOME and the look and feel of KDE, and you've got everything you'd want as a home user. Macs could be looking for a place to hide if Dell